

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN NAURU

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

The story of Nauru carries a warning unlike any other, because this tiny island has already been devoured once by mining, and now stands at the centre of a global fight over whether to do the same thing to the deep sea. Nauru is one of the smallest nations on earth, a single raised coral island in the vast western Pacific, and for the better part of a century it was strip-mined for phosphate — the fossilised residue of countless ancient seabirds — until roughly four-fifths of the whole island, the interior known as **Topside**, was reduced to a barren moonscape of jagged limestone pinnacles, wholly uninhabitable, with the island's remaining people crowded onto the thin coastal ring that is the only living land left to them. The phosphate made Nauru, for a brief and giddy moment, one of the richest places per person on earth; then it ran out, the accumulated wealth was squandered and lost, and the nation was left poor, deeply scarred, and searching desperately for revenue. Now, its old income dwindling, Nauru has become the sponsoring state for a company seeking to mine the deep-sea floor of the Pacific — and has, through a legal manoeuvre, forced the world's seabed authority toward opening that frontier before the rules or the science are anywhere near ready, in a move many see as the island preparing to repeat underwater the very catastrophe that ruined its land. The levers here are real.

The fight over Nauru's deep-sea mining is, distinctively, a global one — for the seabed lies in international waters, and Nauru's own government is driving the project — and the tools are largely international, grounded in a lived warning. The most powerful lever is the **memory of phosphate**: Nauru's own ruin by extraction is the strongest argument against repeating it on the sea, a lived, moral warning the world can see. The **world's seabed governance** — the international seabed authority and the "common heritage of mankind" principle — governs the deep-sea frontier, and the premature push can be resisted there; protest, petition, and advocacy are lawful. A **growing moratorium coalition of nations and the precautionary principle** press for a pause until the science and the rules are ready. The **market refusal** — the buyers, from carmakers to tech companies, who pledge not to purchase seabed metals — undercuts the project's economics. And the **deep-sea science** documenting the harm grounds it all. But these tools have real limits, and this guide states them plainly. Nauru is small and poor and genuinely needs revenue, so the resistance must not merely refuse but help find a better path — a poor nation searching for income cannot simply be told no. Nauru's own government is driving the project, so the domestic democratic levers are limited. The seabed lies in international waters, beyond any one community. These levers all bear on the one great fight the nation's own government has chosen; and though the seabed is the defining struggle, a community facing any other harm at home retains the ordinary tools of a small Pacific democracy — environmental scrutiny, the elected government, and the courts. So aim for what these tools can genuinely deliver — the premature push resisted at the seabed authority, a precautionary pause won through the coalition, the market kept from the metal, the world warned by Nauru's own ruin — and offer the better path: healing Nauru's ruined land and finding revenue that does not repeat the catastrophe.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

You win here not by a domestic vote — the government is the proponent — but by resisting a global harm through global levers, grounded in Nauru's own lived warning. Wield the memory of phosphate as the moral argument the world can see; resist the premature push at the world's seabed authority; press the

precautionary pause through the growing moratorium coalition; keep the market from the metal; and — because a poor nation needs revenue — offer the better path of healing the ruined land and finding income that does not repeat the ruin.

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Nauru's is a distinctive, global fight, and honesty about it is the first discipline. The nation is small and poor and genuinely needs revenue, so mere refusal is not enough — a better path must be offered; its own government is driving the deep-sea project, so domestic levers are limited; and the seabed lies in international waters, beyond any one community. So the realistic aim is the premature push resisted, a precautionary pause won, the market kept from the metal, and the world warned by Nauru's own ruin — through the international governance and coalition, grounded in a lived catastrophe, and offering a better path.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Who Actually Decides

The decisions here run through the world, not one island alone. The **international seabed authority** governs the deep-sea frontier under the "common heritage" principle. The **coalition of nations and the precautionary principle** shape whether it opens. The **market and its buyers** decide whether the metal sells. Nauru's **own government** sponsors the project, and its **people and the memory of phosphate** are the moral witnesses. Map who decides the frontier — the seabed authority, the coalition, the market — before spending a week on it.

How the Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

The deep-sea project advances through Nauru's sponsorship and the seabed authority's rule-making, pushed prematurely toward opening. You enter at the seabed authority, where the premature push and the unready science can be resisted; through the moratorium coalition and the precautionary principle; through the market, where the buyers refuse the metal; and through the world's conscience, where Nauru's own ruin is the warning. Enter globally, grounded in the lived catastrophe, and offering a better path.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Follow the sponsorship: how Nauru's government and the mining company have pushed the seabed authority toward opening the frontier. Follow the science: how far it lags behind the push. Follow the market: which buyers refuse the seabed metal, undercutting the economics. Follow the revenue: what a poor nation genuinely needs, and the better paths to it. The leverage lies in the seabed governance, the precautionary coalition, the market refusal, and the memory of phosphate.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

The watchers here are the international seabed authority, the coalition of nations pressing for a moratorium, the precautionary principle, the market and its refusing buyers, the deep-sea scientists, and the world's public — moved by Nauru's own lived warning. A case engages these global watchers, because the frontier is a global commons.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

No single community easily halts a project its own government drives on a frontier in international waters, and honesty requires saying so. What the global levers can deliver is the premature push resisted, a precautionary pause won, the market kept from the metal. The single most decisive move is **grounding the resistance in Nauru's own ruin by phosphate and pressing it through the seabed governance and the moratorium coalition**, because a nation preparing to repeat underwater the catastrophe that ruined its land is a warning the world can see, and because the seabed authority and the coalition are where the frontier is opened or held. The memory of phosphate is the distinctive lever; the seabed governance the arena; the precautionary coalition the pressure; the market refusal the economics. The realistic prize is a pause and a better path, not a swift domestic stop.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Ask five questions. **What is the harm?** — the deep-sea mining of the Pacific floor, pushed before the science is ready. **Where is it decided?** — the international seabed authority, the coalition, the market. **What is the lived warning?** — Nauru's own ruin by phosphate, repeated underwater. **What does the science show?** — how far the harm outruns the knowledge. **What better path exists?** — the revenue and the healing that do not repeat the ruin. Pick the arena — the seabed authority, the coalition, the market — where the premature push can best be resisted.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Build the case in layers. **Layer one: the harm and the warning** — the deep-sea damage the science warns of, and Nauru's own ruin by phosphate that foreshadows it. **Layer two: the governance and the precaution** — the seabed authority's premature push, the unready science, the precautionary principle, the moratorium coalition. **Layer three: the market and the better path** — the buyers who refuse the metal, and the revenue and land-healing that do not repeat the ruin. A case that grounds the deep-sea harm in Nauru's own lived catastrophe, and presses it through the seabed governance, the coalition, and the market, is one the world can act on.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Gather the **harm record**: the deep-sea science, the ecological risk, the premature push at the seabed authority. Gather the **warning record**: Nauru's own phosphate ruin, the moonscape of Topside, the squandered wealth. Gather the **governance record**: the seabed authority's rules and the coalition's moratorium calls, the precautionary principle. Gather the **market record**: the buyers who refuse the seabed metal. Gather the **better-path record**: the revenue alternatives and the land-healing. Much of this is documented and global.

STEP 3: BUILDING THE GLOBAL COALITION

The coalition here is global, because the fight is. Build with the **Nauruan people and the memory of phosphate**, the moral witnesses; the **coalition of nations** pressing for a moratorium; the **deep-sea scientists** who document the risk; the **market and the refusing buyers**; and the **international conservation movements**. Frame the cause around a lived warning — an island repeating underwater the catastrophe that ruined its land — and, because Nauru is poor and needs revenue, pair the resistance with a

better path, so it is not merely a wealthy world telling a poor nation no.

STEP 4: THE MEMORY, THE SEABED GOVERNANCE & THE MARKET — RESISTING THE FRONTIER

Set expectations honestly: the levers are global and real, but the project is government-driven and the seabed international, so the prize is a pause and a better path, not a swift stop.

The Memory of Phosphate

The most powerful lever is the **memory of phosphate**: Nauru's own ruin by extraction is the strongest argument against repeating it on the sea — a lived, moral warning no argument can match, and one the world can see in the moonscape of Topside.

The Seabed Governance and the Precautionary Coalition

The **world's seabed governance** — the international seabed authority and the "common heritage" principle — governs the frontier, and the premature push can be resisted there. A **growing moratorium coalition of nations and the precautionary principle** press for a pause until the science and rules are ready. Resist the push and press the pause.

The Market Refusal and the Better Path

The **market refusal** — the buyers who pledge not to purchase seabed metals — undercuts the project's economics, and the **better path** of healing the ruined land and finding sustainable revenue answers a poor nation's real need. Pursued together — the memory, the seabed governance and coalition, and the market and better path — these levers resist the frontier while offering Nauru a way that does not repeat the ruin.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Tailor the case to each audience. **For the seabed authority**: here is a premature push to open a frontier before the science is ready. **For the coalition of nations**: here is the case for a precautionary moratorium. **For the market**: here is metal you should refuse to buy. **For the world**: here is an island repeating underwater the catastrophe that ruined its land. **For Nauru itself**: here is a better path to revenue that does not repeat the ruin. **The golden rule**: ground the resistance in Nauru's own lived warning, press it through the seabed governance, the coalition, and the market, and always pair it with a better path for a poor nation.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media and the world's conscience are central to a global fight. Frame the story around **the lived warning**: an island already devoured by phosphate now preparing to repeat the catastrophe on the deep sea, before the science is ready. Carry it through the international press, the conservation and moratorium movements, and the market campaigns. A few cautions: keep it accurate and grounded in the science and Nauru's own history; do not simply shame a poor nation, but pair the warning with a better path; and let the moonscape of Topside and the precautionary science carry the weight.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Keep every message factual, grounded in the lived warning, and paired with a better path.

8A — To the international seabed authority: object to the premature push to open the frontier before the science is ready.

8B — To a coalition-of-nations government: press for the precautionary moratorium.

8C — To a market buyer: ask for the pledge to refuse seabed metals.

8D — On the science: present the deep-sea evidence of harm and the unready knowledge.

8E — On the memory of phosphate: set out Nauru's own ruin as the warning against repeating it.

8F — To a conservation or moratorium movement: coordinate the global campaign.

8G — On the better path: propose the land-healing and sustainable revenue that answer Nauru's need.

8H — To the international public: tell the story of the island repeating its catastrophe, and the better way.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

The first 48 hours: document the premature push at the seabed authority and Nauru's own phosphate ruin; write the one-page warning paired with a better path. **The fastest-moving levers:** the memory of phosphate, the seabed governance and moratorium coalition, and the market refusal. **Emergency action:** where the seabed authority nears a decision, the premature push and the precautionary principle are the sharpest handles — press the coalition and the buyers at once. Throughout, ground it in the lived warning and pair it with a better path.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

The field here is tilted by a poor nation's desperate need for revenue and its own government's drive to mine. Recognise it, and lean on the levers that fit a global fight: the memory of phosphate, the seabed governance and the precautionary coalition, the market refusal. And — crucially — do not merely refuse, but offer a better path, for a poor nation cannot simply be told no. Accept, honestly, that the government drives the project, the seabed is international, and there is no swift domestic stop — so the fight is global, moral, and paired with an alternative.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL DESPERATION — AND WHO BENEFITS

Here the driver is less hidden corruption than a poor nation's genuine desperation for revenue, and a company that stands to profit from its need. Respond through the global channels that hold the frontier: the seabed governance, the precautionary coalition, the market refusal, the deep-sea science, and the world's conscience moved by Nauru's own ruin. **On safety:** Nauru is a small Pacific democracy, so this work is open and lawful; the risk is not physical but the risk of shaming a poor nation rather than helping it. So the resistance must always pair the warning with a better path — the healing of the ruined land, and revenue that does not repeat the catastrophe — so that it stands with the Nauruan people, not against them.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps run in parallel, globally. The lived warning and the science feed the seabed-authority objection, the coalition's moratorium, and the market refusal at once; the Nauruan people and the world's movements press together; the better path runs beneath it all. A rough timeline: **weeks one to four**, document the premature push and the lived warning; **months two onward**, press the seabed authority, the moratorium coalition, and the market, and advance the better path; **through the long global fight**, keep the frontier from opening before the science is ready. The core discipline: warning-grounded, globally pressed, and always paired with a better path.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Nauru's is among the most distinctive fights in this guide, and this guide does not pretend otherwise. It does not claim a single community can halt a project its own government drives on a frontier in international waters, or that a poor nation searching for revenue can simply be told no, or that a landmark victory exists — none of that is true. What it claims is real: that Nauru's own ruin by phosphate is the most powerful argument against repeating it on the sea, a lived warning the world can see; that the world's seabed governance and the "common heritage" principle can resist the premature push; that a growing moratorium coalition and the precautionary principle can press for a pause; and that the market's refusing buyers can undercut the metal — all paired with a better path of healing the ruined land and finding revenue that does not repeat the catastrophe. The levers are global, moral, and market-based, and the prize is a precautionary pause and a better path, not a swift domestic stop. For an island that was devoured once and stands to be the instrument of devouring the deep, that global work — grounded in a lived warning and offering a poor nation a better way — is not a lesser ambition. It is how the world learns, from Nauru's own ruin, not to repeat it.